NON- VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Non- Verbal Communication refers to communication done through gestures, facial expressions, eye contact, touch, tone of voice, dress, space between the people communicating, and ambience, to name a few. Even while sitting quietly, two people can communicate using one of the aforementioned forms of communication. Let us now study various forms of non-verbal communication in detail.

1. Kinesics
2. Paralinguistics
3. Proxemics
4. Chronemics

KINESICS

Kinesics refers to communication through the body language of the parties communicating.

Key Components of Kinesics:

1. Facial Expressions – The face is a powerful tool for expressing emotions like happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, or disgust.
Example: Smiling usually indicates friendliness or approval.

2. Gestures – Movements of the hands, arms, or head that emphasize or complement speech.
Example: Nodding the head signifies agreement

3. Posture – The way a person stands or sits can reveal attitudes, confidence, or openness.
Example: Leaning forward shows interest; crossing arms might suggest defensiveness.

4. Eye Contact – The use of eyes to regulate interaction and show attention or emotion.
Example: Direct eye contact can show confidence or sincerity, while avoiding eye contact might indicate discomfort.



Fig: Images of offensive body postures and correct body postures.

5. Personal Appearance: Personal appearance refers to how one presents themselves through grooming, clothing, and overall physical look. It's a *nonverbal cue* that communicates confidence, professionalism, and attitude before one even speaks.

Example: A neatly dressed engineer during a presentation creates a positive impression even before beginning the talk.

Wearing formals in an interview → conveys seriousness and readiness.

Wearing casuals at a technical fest → shows approachability and creativity.

Aspect	Tips	Example
1. Clothing	Choose clean, well-fitted, ironed clothes suitable for the occasion.	Formal shirt and trousers for presentations.
2. Colour Choice	Use subtle, professional colors (blue, white, grey).	Avoid flashy or neon shades in interviews.
3. Footwear	Should be clean, closed-toe, and appropriate for the outfit.	Black formal shoes vs. sports shoes.
4. Grooming	Hair neat, nails trimmed, minimal accessories.	Avoid messy hairstyles or too much perfume.
5. Cultural Sensitivity	Dress modestly and respectfully according to context.	Wearing traditional attire during cultural events.

For example: A. When a boss gestures a thumbs up to his/her colleague, it could mean that he/she liked the idea or is giving him/her a go-ahead.

B. Sometimes during a conversation, a person may pound the table to express anger or disagreement over something. Though this is a negative form of expression, it is still not uncommon.

C. Think of the stare that your father may have given you when you may have said something inappropriate. This is another example of non-verbal communication through affective displays.

D. Many times, during face-to-face interaction, people may nod to show their agreement or even disagreement over what is being discussed. This nodding too delivers the message without the use of any words.

E. During interviews or situations where a person is uncomfortable, some people are seen shaking their legs, constantly. Such a body language clearly shows nervousness or a lack of confidence in the person shaking his/her legs.

Therefore, even without the person realizing that he/she is communicating something, the message is sent to others around him/her.

PARALINGUISTICS

Paralinguistics refers to spoken communication through changes in the rate of speech, accent, volume, voice modulation, pitch, and fluency. It is not only what is being said is important but also how it is said plays a role in communication.

Key Elements of Paralinguistics:

1. Tone of Voice – Reflects emotion and attitude.

Example: A warm tone suggests friendliness; a harsh tone may indicate anger or irritation.

2. Pitch – The highness or lowness of the voice.

Example: A high pitch might show excitement or nervousness; a low pitch might suggest seriousness or calmness.

3. Volume – The loudness or softness of speech.

Example: Speaking loudly can indicate confidence or aggression; speaking softly can show shyness or politeness.

4. Rate of Speech (Pace) – How fast or slow one speaks.

Example: Fast speech can show enthusiasm or anxiety; slow speech can suggest thoughtfulness or sadness.

5. Pauses and Silence – Breaks or gaps in speech that can carry meaning.

Example: A pause before answering might show hesitation or careful thinking.

6. Voice Quality – The texture or character of one's voice.

Example: A smooth voice can sound soothing, while a raspy one may seem tense or emotional.

For example, A. A simple sentence like "Come here!" can be said authoritatively or endearingly, depending on the tone of voice of the sender.

B. A storyteller lowering their voice to build suspense.

C. "Stop right there!" used to emphasize anger, urgency, or command.

PROXEMICS

Proxemics is a branch of **non-verbal communication** that studies how **space and distance** are used between people during interactions. It deals with how physical space communicates **feelings, relationships, and social meanings**.

The concept of proxemics was introduced by **anthropologist Edward T. Hall** in the 1960s. He suggested that the way people use personal space varies across cultures, situations, and relationships.

Zones of Personal Space (according to Edward T. Hall):

1. Intimate Distance (0 to 18 inches / 0–45 cm)

Used with close relationships: family members, romantic partners, or very close friends. Involves touch, whispering, and a high level of trust.

2. Personal Distance (1.5 to 4 feet / 45–120 cm)

Used for conversations with friends or relatives. Comfortable for personal but not intimate communication.

3. Social Distance (4 to 12 feet / 1.2–3.6 meters)

Used in formal or professional interactions. Common in classrooms, workplaces, or business meetings.

4. Public Distance (12 feet and beyond / 3.6+ meters)

Used for public speaking, lectures, or addressing large groups. Little personal interaction; voice and gestures are used more to communicate.

For example, A. Someone steps back when another person stands too close — showing discomfort with invasion of personal space.

B. People may avoid eye contact or turn slightly away to create a sense of "psychological distance."

C. People forming a circle shows inclusion; someone left outside the circle can feel excluded.

CHRONEMICS

Chronemics refers to communication using time as a factor. Chronemics is the study of how humans perceive, use, and communicate through time, including aspects like punctuality, waiting, and scheduling. It is a subdiscipline of non-verbal communication that analyzes how time is a resource that can be spent, saved, or wasted, and it explores cultural differences, such as monochronic and polychronic time systems.

Let us understand this with the help of **an example**. A boss who comes to office on time every day, subtly communicates it to his/her employees that they too are expected to be on time every day.

Key aspects of chronemics:

Monochronic: This approach involves doing one thing at a time, with a strong focus on schedules, punctuality, and promptness.

Polychronic: This approach allows for multitasking and flexible scheduling, with a greater emphasis on social relationships than on strict time management.